



Sports Foundation said that India has to target select sports if it hopes to churn out a record medal tally at its home Olympics.

"Yes, host nations perform well. There are fundamental reasons for it. You are used to the conditions. You also have choice of sports and more quotas. Just the last Olympics, France made a 94 per cent jump. The government has to have a targeted funding for select sports. You cannot have it spread across 33 sports. We did an exercise at Sports Authority of India in 2019, which concluded that only our eight high-priority sports would not get us into the position we want to reach. We identified six more sports, which were swimming, fencing, judo, cycling, table tennis, and one more," he said.

Dola Banerjee, another Commonwealth Games, medallist said that the work for the 2036

Olympics has to start right away, and at the correct target age group.

"Athens was too big a stage for me. I had never seen such a big event unfold. It was a unique experience. I was better prepared by 2008. Now everyone is targeting medals, not merely participation. And if we have to target 2036, then we do not have a lot of time. We have to prepare 10-year-olds for that, starting now. "To identify talent, we need 100 to 150 athletes to go out and look for them. We can get a lot of participation from schools if we ask them to implement two to three sports. And across different age groups. So, we have to go closer to the schools," she said.

Deepthi Bopaiah, board member, GoSports Foundation, said that India also has to chart out its course for the Paralympics 2036.

"If you look at the history of

Deepthi Bopaiah, board member of GoSports Foundation speaks during the panel titled: The Host Nation Effect: Why Olympics hosts outperform and can India do it too? R.V. MOORTHY

Paralympics, we were just 19 athletes in Rio. There was no reporter on ground, no coverage. On day three, we won the first medal and the media was chasing us after that. We did not expect to win that medal. Cut to Paris, we had 84 athletes and 29 medals in a three Games cycle. What we noticed is that India is in top five in people with disabilities. Today, sport is a way to create identity for them. When you target 2036, the Paralympics you will have close to 100 medals. But it is a process. I just urge that policies have to be driven in the true form of inclusion with the Paralympics and Olympics," she said.

